

SRI LANKA EMERGENCY RESPONSE & DISASTER SURVIVAL GUIDE

National Disaster Management Framework | Demo Data for Training Purposes

1. Flood Response (Sri Lanka Specific)

Sri Lanka is highly susceptible to floods, primarily driven by the South-West Monsoon (May to September) and the North-East Monsoon (December to February). Riverine floods from the Kelani, Kalu, Gin, and Nilwala rivers frequently affect the Western, Southern, and Sabaragamuwa provinces.

Early Warning Signs

- **Continuous Rainfall:** Heavy rainfall exceeding 100mm within 24 hours often triggers a "Watch" level alert from the Irrigation Department.
- **Rising River Levels:** Monitor the gauge levels at key stations like Hanwella (Kelani River) or Putupaula (Kalu River). Rapid rises in river height are immediate indicators of upstream saturation.
- **Unusual Water Color:** If local streams turn muddy brown or carry significant debris (branches, plastics), it indicates high-velocity runoff.

Evacuation Procedures

1. Upon receiving a **Red Alert** from the Disaster Management Centre (DMC), immediately pack your 72-hour survival kit.
2. Turn off the main electricity switch and close gas cylinder valves to prevent fires or electrocution.
3. Move valuables and essential documents to higher shelves or a secondary floor if available.
4. Follow designated evacuation routes provided by the Grama Niladhari (Village Officer). Avoid shortcutting through low-lying paddy fields.

Safe Zones & High Ground

- **Colombo:** Elevated areas in Sri Jayawardenepura Kotte, Malabe, and designated multi-story school buildings in Kelaniya.
- **Galle:** High ground near the Dadalla area or Karapitiya.
- **Matara:** Elevated temples and school grounds in the Akuressa and Kamburupitiya highlands.

If Trapped

Do not attempt to swim through moving water. Even 6 inches of moving water can knock an adult off their feet. Move to the highest level of the building. Do not climb into a closed attic; you may become trapped by rising water. Signal for help by waving a bright cloth or using a flashlight (torch) at night.

2. Cyclone & Tropical Storm Preparedness

The Bay of Bengal is a frequent source of cyclonic storms that impact Sri Lanka's Northern and Eastern coasts. The Department of Meteorology uses a three-tier warning system: Yellow (Advisory), Amber (Warning), and Red (Danger).

Before the Storm

- **Home Fortification:** Trim overhanging tree branches near your roof. Secure loose roof tiles or sheets with "cyclone straps" or heavy sandbags.
- **Coastal Protection:** Residents in **Trincomalee, Batticaloa, and Jaffna** should move boats and fishing gear to inland storage facilities.
- **Emergency Kit:** Ensure you have a portable radio with spare batteries, as cellular networks often fail during high winds.

During the Storm

1. Stay indoors. Move to the center of the house, away from windows and glass doors.
2. If the "eye" of the storm passes, there will be a temporary calm. **Do not go outside.** The winds will return from the opposite direction with equal or greater intensity shortly.
3. Keep a whistle handy to signal rescuers if the structure collapses.

After the Storm

Be extremely cautious of downed power lines. In Sri Lanka, many power lines are overhead and may be hidden in standing water or fallen debris. Treat every wire as "live." Do not consume tap water without boiling, as storm surges often contaminate wells with seawater and sewage.

3. Landslide Response

Landslides are a significant threat in the central highlands, particularly in **Ratnapura, Kegalle, Nuwara Eliya, and Badulla** districts during heavy monsoon rains.

Warning Signs

- New cracks appearing in the ground, roads, or building foundations.
- Trees, fences, or telephone poles beginning to tilt or lean.
- "Mud-curls" or sudden springs of water appearing on slopes where the ground was previously dry.
- A faint rumbling sound that increases in intensity, similar to a train or a low-flying jet.

Immediate Evacuation

1. If you suspect a landslide is imminent, do not wait for an official warning. Move immediately to a flat, open area away from the path of the slope.
2. Inform your neighbors as you leave by shouting or using a hand-bell.
3. Avoid river valleys and gully areas, as landslides can transition into debris flows that travel long distances down stream beds.

If Caught in a Landslide

If the ground begins to move and you cannot escape, curl into a tight ball and protect your head. This "fetal position" provides the best protection for your vital organs and head from tumbling debris. If you are buried, try to create an air pocket around your face and signal by making noise rather than shouting to conserve oxygen.

4. Earthquake & Tsunami Response

While Sri Lanka is not on a major plate boundary, intra-plate seismic activity and distant oceanic subduction zones (like the Sunda Trench) pose threats.

Drop, Cover, and Hold On

- **DROP:** Get down on your hands and knees.
- **COVER:** Take cover under a sturdy table or desk. In Sri Lankan homes without such furniture, move to an interior corner of the room away from glass.
- **HOLD ON:** Stay in place until the shaking stops.

Tsunami Awareness

If you are near the coast (Negombo, Hikkaduwa, Arugam Bay) and feel a strong earthquake lasting more than 20 seconds, or if you see the sea receding significantly, **MOVE INLAND IMMEDIATELY**. Do not wait for a siren. Move at least 2km inland or to an elevation of at least 20 meters (65 feet).

Vertical Evacuation

In densely populated coastal areas like **Galle Fort or Matara**, if horizontal evacuation is blocked by traffic, move to the 3rd floor or higher of a reinforced concrete building. Schools and hotels are often the most stable structures in these zones.

5. Medical Emergencies & First Aid

In a disaster, professional medical help may be delayed. Knowing basic life-saving techniques is vital.

1990 Suwa Seriya

The 1990 Suwa Seriya service is the primary pre-hospital emergency provider in Sri Lanka. Call **1990** for life-threatening emergencies. Be prepared to give your exact location, often using landmarks like "Near the Bo Tree" or "Opposite the Sub Post Office."

Snake Bite Protocol

Flood waters often displace snakes (Cobra, Russell's Viper, Krait) into human dwellings. 1. Keep the victim calm and still. 2. Immobilize the limb with a splint. 3. Do **NOT** cut the wound or attempt to suck out venom. 4. Transport the victim immediately to the nearest Government Hospital, as they carry the necessary anti-venom.

Water & Sanitation

Diarrheal diseases spread rapidly in camps. Use 3 drops of chlorine or 1 teaspoon of bleach per 20 liters of water if boiling is not possible. Ensure hands are washed with soap before eating any dry rations provided by relief agencies.

6. Emergency Contacts — Sri Lanka

Service	Number
Police Emergency	119
Ambulance (Suwa Seriya)	1990
Disaster Management Centre (DMC)	117 / 011-2136136
Fire & Rescue	110
National Hospital (Colombo)	011-2691111
Sri Lanka Red Cross	011-2691095

District DMC Contacts

- **Colombo:** 011-2136222
- **Kandy:** 081-2233211
- **Galle:** 091-2234500
- **Jaffna:** 021-2222000
- **Trincomalee:** 026-2222111

7. 72-Hour Survival Kit Checklist

Every Sri Lankan household should maintain a ready-to-go bag. Use a waterproof backpack if possible.

- **Water:** 3 Liters per person per day.
- **Food:** Biscuits, Samaposhha, canned fish, and dried fruits. Avoid items that require much water to cook (like raw rice) unless you have a portable stove.

- **Health:** Paracetamol, antiseptic cream, bandages, and a 1-week supply of chronic medications (Diabetes/BP).
- **Documents:** National Identity Card (NIC), Birth Certificates, Bank Books, and Land Deeds sealed in a heavy-duty plastic Ziploc bag.
- **Tools:** Flashlight with extra batteries, whistle, multi-purpose knife, and a power bank for mobile phones.

8. Community Response & Volunteering

Sri Lankan culture relies heavily on "Shramadana" (communal work). In a disaster, the first responders are always your neighbors.

Neighborhood Plans

Identify the elderly or disabled members in your "Mawatha" (street). Assign two able-bodied neighbors to assist them during an evacuation. Establish a "Phone Tree" where one person calls five others to spread warnings quickly.

Psychological First Aid

Disasters cause immense stress. Listen to survivors without forcing them to talk. Provide accurate information to reduce rumors and anxiety. For children, maintain a calm demeanor; they take their emotional cues from adults.

9. Children & School Safety

Children are among the most vulnerable during floods and landslides. Schools in Sri Lanka follow the National School Safety Guidelines.

- **Memorization:** Children should know their full name, parents' names, and a contact phone number by heart.
- **Safe Haven:** If separated during school hours, children are taught to stay with their teachers at the designated "Assembly Point" (usually the school playground) until a registered guardian arrives.
- **Communication:** Use simple, honest language to explain the event. "The rain has caused the river to come into the streets, so we are staying at this safe house for a while."